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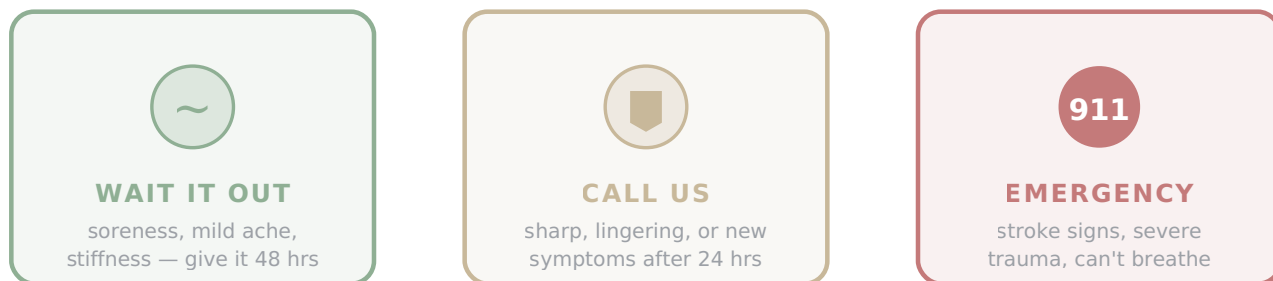
# When to call us, wait it out, or skip us entirely.

*Bodies do strange things sometimes. This is a short, honest guide for figuring out which bucket a new symptom falls into — without spiraling at 11pm.*

A short read · About 5 minutes · **Save this — it's the one to keep handy**

Most aches and pains do not need a phone call. Most do not need an emergency room either. The trick is knowing the few that genuinely do, and not losing sleep over the rest.

Here is the framework. It fits on one screen. The rest of this guide just unpacks it.



*Three buckets. Most symptoms land in the first one. A handful land in the second. A small number need bucket three.*

## 01 Bucket one: probably wait it out

Wait it out

Mild aches and "I just got adjusted" feelings

Most after-care reactions belong here. Things to expect and not worry about:

- Soreness similar to the day after a workout, rated 1 to 4 out of 10
- Mild stiffness on first standing in the morning that loosens with movement
- Feeling tired, hungry, or unusually sleepy the evening of an adjustment
- A familiar ache in an area that has flared before, behaving the same as before
- Joint pops or clicks that are not painful

The rule of thumb for bucket one is the **48-hour rule**. If a symptom is mild, familiar, and improving — even slowly — over 48 hours, it is probably running its course. Heat, hydration, gentle movement, and sleep are the boring tools that quietly handle most of these.

Bucket one is also where home practice does most of its work. The exercises a chiropractor prescribes are designed for exactly these kinds of normal recoveries.

## 02 Bucket two: pick up the phone

Call us

When something has changed and is not settling

A phone call to the office is the right move when:

- Pain is sharper, more constant, or in a new place since the last visit
- Soreness has not improved at all after 48 hours, or it is getting worse
- A specific exercise causes pain that does not fade after stopping
- Numbness or tingling shows up in an arm or leg
- Headaches start happening more often or feel different from usual
- A new injury occurred between visits — fall, car accident, awkward lift
- Pain is bad enough to wake up from sleep
- Any concern that just keeps rattling around in the head — that one counts too

Front desk staff are not annoyed by these calls. They are useful calls. They give the doctor a chance to adjust the plan — sometimes by changing the protocol, sometimes by having the patient come in early, sometimes by referring out to someone better suited to the issue. None of those decisions can be made if the patient does not call.

*A two-minute phone call has saved more recoveries than any single adjustment. Most of what gets fixed in chiropractic happens because the patient said something.*

## 03 Bucket three: skip the office, call 911

Some symptoms are not chiropractic problems at all. They are medical emergencies that need an ambulance, a hospital, or both. The list below is short on purpose. Memorizing it is one of the few things that genuinely matters.

Call 911 or go to the ER for

**FAST signs of stroke:** Face drooping on one side · Arm weakness when raised · Speech slurred or strange · Time to call right away. Also: sudden severe headache unlike any before, sudden vision loss,

severe chest pain or trouble breathing, loss of bladder or bowel control, weakness or numbness in both legs at once, or any major trauma.

None of these are subtle. If something on that list is happening, it is happening loudly. Trust the gut feeling that says *this is different*. An ER visit that turns out to be nothing is a great outcome. The other direction is not.

## 04 The "I do not know which bucket this is" problem

This is the most honest situation of all. A symptom is uncomfortable but not dramatic. It might be normal soreness, or it might be something else, and there is no clean way to tell from the inside.

The default answer is to call the office. Phone triage is what it is for. A two-minute conversation usually clarifies the bucket, and clarifying the bucket is most of the work.

The exception is when something on the bucket-three list is happening. In that case, do not call the office first — call 911 or get to an ER. The chiropractor will get the records later. Speed matters more than continuity in those moments.

### A USEFUL RULE

When in doubt and not sure: call the office. When in doubt *and* something feels seriously wrong: call 911. The cost of a wrong guess in the calm direction is much higher than in the cautious direction.

## 05 The bottom line

Three buckets. Most things go in the first. A handful go in the second. A small number — and they tend to be obvious — go in the third.

The 48-hour rule covers most of bucket one. A phone call covers all of bucket two. 911 covers bucket three. That is the whole framework. Patients who internalize this end up calmer in the moment *and* faster to act when speed actually matters — which is what good triage is supposed to do.

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**About this guide.** This is general patient education and is not medical advice for any specific person. The lists above are common examples, not a complete inventory. Anyone uncertain about a symptom should err on the side of calling — the office in non-urgent situations, or 911 / the nearest emergency department in urgent ones. **If a symptom feels like a medical emergency, do not wait to read this — call 911.**